

INTRODUCTION TO SOCIOLOGY

I. OVERVIEW

Welcome to Introduction to Sociology! As the name of the course suggests, what we will be doing in this class is to get you acquainted with sociology, hopefully in the most useful way for you. We will be talking about sociology as a perspective, a discipline, and a profession. Weekly lectures and discussions in class will be based on sustained engagement with (mostly) scholarly work from sociologists. This engagement will culminate in a final essay assignment that challenges you to apply what is called the "sociological imagination" to a topic of your choice.

Core contribution: This course fulfills one of the two Social Science Core requirements of the Core Curriculum. When you complete the Core, it is expected that you will achieve all of the learning goals, listed [here](#). Given its focus on some of the most complex problems facing global society today, sociology is a particularly rich discipline to explore the objectives of the core. Sociological inquiry pushes students to question the assumptions that many have regarding why and how the world around us is the way it is. Students will thus strengthen these critical thinking skills that are necessary for success in all disciplines and careers in a complex world. Class discussions aim to create a conducive environment for students to converse about complex topics. The assignments are designed to enhance students' ability to articulate their thoughts into structured and well-supported pieces of writing.

1. Objectives

There are three main things that I hope to achieve:

- First, to introduce you to what is called the "sociological imagination". It's a particular perspective that individuals can apply to understand contemporary social problems and how they relate to their own life and decisions. You will be encouraged to apply this perspective – to reflect and think critically about how your own everyday experiences are driven by wider historical, social, economic, and political forces.
- Secondly, to give you a "taste" of what sociological research is saying about important contemporary topics. In other words, to provide you with an informed view based on sociological research.

- Finally, to stage a sort of mini "job fair" so you can see the actual work that sociologists do from day to day. Hopefully I will entice you enough that you will go on to pursue more advanced sociology class here at BC, and perhaps beyond.

There are some important auxiliary goals to the class. One thing that you will be practicing quite a bit is to read a dense piece of text and separate the wheat from the chaff. Another is critical thinking, as you engage with the ideas of the readings. Then, use what you've read and craft a coherent argument in writing. Finally, I want you to hopefully have fun.

2. Substance of the Course

I have structured the course to introduce you to three facets of sociology.

- Sociology in practice: What kinds of research are sociologists engaged in? What kinds of questions excite them? What do they find? How do the findings inform us of social reality? Across 13 sessions, we will discuss five big topics: (1) Inequality and meritocracy, (2) Race, (3) Gender, (4) The environment, and (5) Corporations.
- Sociology as a perspective: How do sociologists perceive society? Over 6 sessions, we will discuss the "classics" in sociology. Part of the first session is reserved to talk about why we bother with writings that are now centuries old.
- Sociology as a profession: What do sociologists actually do all day? What can sociologists offer to the public discourse? What do they think about themselves? We will discuss these questions in the last 2 sessions.

The main medium through which we will get acquainted with sociology will be what my advisor had called a "buffet" of readings. More specifically, each session will have 1-3 readings that you will be required to read in depth and provide a short response (more on this later). These readings can be dense. However, the intention is not to get you to understand everything, but to encourage you to consistently engage with these topics and perspectives, and at the end, dive deeper into one or two topics that really resonate with you.

A secondary medium that I have found to be effective is documentaries. These are occasions for us to keep sticking with the important sociological topics without having to engage with the drier scholastic language. You will be required to write

some commentaries on these topics with reference to the materials we have covered in class (more on this later as well).

While it is more customary to start a class like this with an introduction of major sociological theories (like Durkheim, Marx, Weber, and other big names), I am starting the class with relatively more current empirical research. This first part of the course is designed to supply you with empirical "bricks". My reasoning is that an understanding of concrete problems that sociological research engages in will make it easier for us to draw a connection with the broader perspective discussed in part two. On a practical note, I also want to supply you with materials for your essay a bit sooner.

Finally, sociology is very broad and there will be important areas of scholarship/research that we will not be able to cover in depth, such as queer theory, social networks, the law and so on. We also will not discuss at length the solutions to the myriads of social problems that will be made apparent in the course materials. I will try to provide additional materials for these topics if you are interested.

3. Lesson Plan & Communication

A typical lesson will start with a short 5-minute discussion in groups of 2 or 3 on the readings of the sessions based on the response you submit for the week. We will reconvene and discuss as a class the points you raised with your classmates. The bulk of a session will be reserved for the lecture. The last 5-10 minutes will be for questions and comments if you have any. I do not have any restrictions on classroom technologies, only that you refrain from using phones during discussions and lectures.

I encourage everyone to ask questions and participate in discussions. While we will need to reserve a set amount of time for going through key points for each week, I can allocate more time towards discussion should the need arise.

Office hours are Mondays and Wednesdays 1:00PM - 2:00PM (before class) or by appointment. If you have any questions pertaining to the materials, I strongly encourage you to come to the designated office hours as they are better answered in person. If the office hours do not work for you, please send me an email and we will find a time.

4. Additional Resources

Writing Guide: Writing for Sociology [[link](#)]

Citation software: Zotero Guide from the library [[link](#)]

II. CLASS POLICIES

1. Accommodation ...

2. Use of Artificial Intelligence

I generally discourage the use of Artificial Intelligence tools like ChatGPT for this class for both summarizing the readings and for the essay assignment. Doing so defeats the purpose of engaging with the source materials; these tools have also been known to generate wrong or non-existent information.

3. Academic Integrity

Cheating on exams and plagiarism on written assignments are not tolerated. Please familiarize yourself with the university's policy. Be sure to use quotation marks when using direct quotes and cite accordingly when quoting (or paraphrasing) someone else's words. Failure to comply will result in automatic failure of the assignment and a report to the Dean and the Committee on Academic Integrity.

III. ASSIGNMENTS

There are three main components to your grade: Participation (10%), weekly responses (45%), and essays (45%).

Assignments will be submitted through Canvas. Grades will be posted on Canvas.

1. Participation (10%)

Participation will be graded through roll calling at the beginning of class. If you cannot make it, please notify me at least 1 day ahead. You are allowed to miss two (2) classes.

2. Weekly Responses (10 x 3% = 30%)

Each week, you will need to submit a short response to ALL of the readings for that week BEFORE class. The response should be at least 200 words and at most 500 words. For weeks with in-class movies showing, you only need to respond to the reading. For example, response 1 should be on the Berger and Luckman reading and Susan Silbey's short video. Response 2 should be on the two Desmond's readings. Response 3 should be on Teo You Yenn's book chapter and another reading (TBD at the moment).

The idea is not to force you to understand everything, but to get you to engage and generate ideas, questions, discussions to bring to class, where I can provide more context and clarification.

These responses are **due 12:00 PM Sunday every week** with some exceptions. There are a total of THIRTEEN (13) CHANCES for responses (see section V on course materials and class schedule). You only need to do TEN (10) - The choice for which ones to do this is up to you, or you can do all 13 and I will pick the top 10. The response should:

- Present AT LEAST ONE ARGUMENT or ONE CONCEPT for EACH reading that you think is most persuasive, or that you find most interesting according to your own understanding and explain why (2%).
- Provide at least one question you have on the materials (1%).

A short note about reading: All readings will have (1) some kind of question(s) that it seeks to answer, (2) the answer to said question(s) in the form of arguments, and (3) evidence in support of said arguments. These are the areas students are advised to focus on to gain a good understanding of a piece of sociological research. My personal process is to have a note open with three corresponding questions (What is the question(s)? What are the answers provided? How are those answers substantiated?) and answer them as I read.

Extracting the aforementioned information from a text is easier for some readings than for others. In some readings, such as journal articles, the authors often specify quite clearly what they mean to say, giving you "signposts" in the abstract, introduction, and conclusion, with more details in the "findings" sections. In other readings, however, the authors can "bury the lead". Book chapters generally work the same as a journal article - although identifying the "sections" may require a bit more work; and theoretical pieces are slightly more difficult than that.

Some of the readings are quantitative work that uses methods you may not be familiar with - Fret not! The advanced methodology is not the focus of this course. You can safely skim the methods part and spend more time focusing on the arguments of the readings. That said, we will be revisiting a selection of these methods sections towards the end of the semester to discuss how sociological research is done (week 16 - see section V of the syllabus). There will be no response due for that week.

3. Movie commentaries (4 x 7.5% = 30%):

We will watch snippets of seven documentaries in class across the semester. These are:

- Sicko (2007) directed by Micheal Moore
- Same week: The 13th (2016) directed by Ava DuVernay
- The House We Live in (2003) directed by Eduardo Bonilla-Silva
- The Hunting Ground (2015) directed by Dick Kirby
- The Power of Big Oil, Part 2: Doubt (2022) by PBS Frontline
- Inside Job (2010) directed by Charles Ferguson
- Marxism (1986) directed by Stuart Hall

You are required to write a commentary (**max 800 words**) on FOUR (4) of these documentaries, with reference to AT LEAST TWO (2) readings from the class and the concepts we discussed. The readings are not restricted to those of the immediate past week – You can use ANY of the past readings. There are SIX (6) chances for you to submit these commentaries, you only have to do four, or do all six and I will take the highest four.

These commentaries are due the **Friday one (1) week** after the in-class airing of the documentary, except for commentary for “The Hunting Ground,” which is due two weeks later (see section V).

4. Essays (Preparation 15% + Final essay 15% = 30%):

You are required to write an argumentative essay (**max 2,500 words**) that draws the connection between materials discussed in class and one (1) piece of contemporary news. This is, in effect, a practice of applying a “sociological imagination” to current affairs and requires you to possess a relatively good grasp of the readings.

For this assignment:

- You will first need to choose a topic from the ones we discussed in class.
- Next, you will choose a news article on said topic from mainstream news sources with good reporting quality: NYT, WaPo, WJS, Reuters, AP, Financial Times, Bloomberg, etc. Be sure to pick NEWS ARTICLES, not OPINION PIECES.
- You should then pick at least TWO (2) readings from the class (you can also pick from the supplementary materials). The essay should explain how the content of the news can be understood by leveraging the perspectives or empirical findings in these readings. If you want to center a source that is not in the reading list, check with me first.

Some ways you can approach the essay: You can comment on, for example, what the news is a case of (e.g. “the news depicts a

case of meritocracy perpetuating inequality”) and explain why you think that is, drawing similarity with the readings. The connection does not have to be only supportive in nature - you can suggest how the news is a counterexample to the arguments in the writing. You can also do a media analysis of the news itself - what it presents, what it obscures, and how it is illustrative of the arguments in the readings.

This assignment is separated into two parts. Preparation is worth 25% and the essay itself is 20%. Details are below.

Preparation (15%)

The preparation is meant for you to engage with crafting and writing an argument - It's meant to be a kind of “trial and error”, so do not worry about getting things 100% right and focus on working towards a coherent and well-supported argument.

There are two components to the preparation:

By ... - Coming up with a topic and producing an outline (maximum two pages, 5%): In this outline, you should include:

- (a) The topic of your choice
- (b) The news sources and the readings you are connecting it to
- (c) Your main argument
- (d) Your main supporting arguments
- (e) Some elaboration of the supporting arguments (1-2 sentences)

By ... - A partial draft (at least 500 words, 10%): The draft should include AT LEAST the introduction, and either a built-out sub-argument or some further elaboration across different arguments. This draft does not need to be perfect. You do not need any formatting for this draft. For example, sources do not need to be properly cited, you can just write the name of the reading or author with the week that reading is for.

My comments for all these steps can be expected one, at most two weeks after the deadline.

The Paper (15%)

The paper will be due at..., though I'd rather you hand it in sooner so you can focus on your finals. The essay will be assessed based on the following criteria:

- **Grasp of the material:** You should produce a relatively accurate summary of both the news article and the readings of your choice.

- **Coherence:** This is an argumentative essay. You need to have a main argument, and it needs to be well supported by sub-arguments, all of which need to relate back to the main argument.
- **Well-supported argument:** If you are relating the news article to Rivera's Pedigree, for example, I would expect either direct quotes or summaries of her arguments from the excerpts we will read and an elaboration on how they are relevant to the point you are trying to make. Additional outside sources, both academic and news are fine, but the two-readings-from-class requirement should still be the focus.
- **Writing:** Grammar, sentence clarity, and proper citations and bibliography (can be any format so long as it is consistent)

5. Extra Credits (5%)

In addition to the other components, students can choose to write an essay (max 1,500 words) on one of the supplementary readings listed below (page details can be found in section V).

1. Excerpts from Suicide (Durkheim)
2. Manifesto of the Communist Party (Marx & Engels)
3. Excerpts from the Protestant Ethics (Weber)
4. Degrees of Inequality (Mullen)
5. Color-blind Racism (Bonilla-Silva)
6. Doing Gender (West & Zimmerman)
7. Hegemonic Femininities and Intersectional Domination (Hamilton et al.)
8. Interrogating the Treadmill of Production (Gould et al.)
9. Inventing Equal Opportunity (Dobbin)

IV. GRADING POLICIES

Grading scale:

A=100-94; A-=93-91

B+=90-88; B=87-84; B-=83-81

C+=80-78; C=77-74; C-=73-71

D+=70-68; D=67-61

F=60 and below.

Late assignments: Please speak with me or email me prior to the due date of an assignment if an extension is needed. With no

communication, assignments will automatically lose 5% then 10% for each additional day late.

Grade concerns: If you wish to challenge a grade, please: (1) wait 24 hours after receiving your score, (2) email me a short summary of your concerns, refer to the assignment requirements and instructor feedback, and (3) wait for my reply so we can set up an appointment to meet.

V. COURSE MATERIALS & CLASS SCHEDULE

All readings can be downloaded from this online folder [Google Drive Link].

Week / Due	Topic	Readings
PART 0: INTRODUCTION No supplementary readings		
Week 1 No response	Introduction	Syllabus
	The sociological imagination: What does sociology offer?	Mills, Charles Wright. 1959. <i>The Sociological Imagination</i> . Read: pp.3-24 ("The Promise") . Students are encouraged to also read Chapter 2: Grand Theory (pp. 25-49)
Week 2 Response 1	No class	No class
	The social construction of reality: What does it mean when we say something is "socially constructed"?	Berger, Peter L., and Thomas Luckmann. 1966. <i>The Social Construction of Reality: A Treatise in the Sociology of Knowledge</i> . Read: pp.70-85 ("Origins of Institutionalization") Silbey, Susan. Invocations of Law on Snowy Streets (video). Watch at home: [link]
PART 1: SOCIOLOGY IN PRACTICE		
<i>Inequality and meritocracy</i> Supplementary readings: Mullen, Ann L. 2011. <i>Degrees of Inequality: Culture, Class, and Gender in American Higher Education</i> . Read: pp.72-117 ("Deciding to Go to College"; "Choosing Colleges")		
Week 3 Response 2	The institutionalization of poverty: Why does poverty persist in America?	Desmond, Matthew. 2023. "Why Poverty Persists in America." <i>The New York Times</i> , March 9.

		Desmond, Matthew. 2012. "Eviction and the Reproduction of Urban Poverty." <i>American Journal of Sociology</i> 118(1):88-133.
	Movie in class: Moore, Michael 2007. <i>Sicko</i> (documentary)	
Week 4 Movie commentary for "Sicko"	Narratives of inequality and meritocracy	Teo, You Yenn. 2018. <i>This Is What Inequality Looks Like</i> . Singapore: Ethos Books. Read: Introduction [link]
	How is meritocracy "taught"?	Khan, Shamus. 2013. <i>Privilege: The Making of an Adolescent Elite at St. Paul's School</i> . Read: pp.1-17 ("Introduction"); pp.52-73 ("Finding One's Place")
<i>Race</i> Supplementary readings: Hirschman, Author Dan. 2020. "Levels of Racism: Individual, Organizational, Institutional, and Systemic." <i>Scatterplot</i>. Retrieved August 2, 2024 (https://scatter.wordpress.com/2020/06/22/levels-of-racism-individual-organizational-institutional-and-systemic/). Bonilla-Silva, Eduardo. 2017. <i>Racism without Racists: Color-Blind Racism and the Persistence of Racial Inequality in America</i>. Fifth edition. Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers. Read: pp. 25-72 ("The New Racism")		
Week 5 Response 4	Race and employment: How does one's race impact one's chances in the job market?	Pager, Devah. 2003. "The Mark of a Criminal Record." <i>American Journal of Sociology</i> 108(5):937-75.
	Race and incarceration: Racial differences and their long-term impact	Alexander, Michelle. 2012. <i>The New Jim Crow: Mass Incarceration in the Age of Colorblindness</i> . Read: pp.1-19 ("Introduction")
Week 6 Response 5	Empires and policing: How does what happens in faraway colonies matter for what's happening at home?	Go, Julian. 2020. "The Imperial Origins of American Policing: Militarization and Imperial Feedback in the Early 20th Century." <i>American Journal of Sociology</i>

		125(5):1193-1254. Read: pp.1193-1215; pp.1238-45
	Movie in class: Bonilla-Silva, Eduardo et al. 2003. The House We Live in (documentary)	
<i>Gender at home and across borders</i> Supplementary readings: West, Candace, and Don H. Zimmerman. 1987. "Doing Gender." <i>Gender and Society</i> 1(2):125-51. Hamilton, Laura T., Elizabeth A. Armstrong, J. Lotus Seeley, and Elizabeth M. Armstrong. 2019. "Hegemonic Femininities and Intersectional Domination." <i>Sociological Theory</i> 37(4):315-41. doi: 10.1177/0735275119888248 . Ortiga, Yasmin Y., Kellynn Wee, and Brenda S. A. Yeoh. 2021. "Connecting Care Chains and Care Diamonds: The Elderly Care Skills Regime in Singapore." <i>Global Networks</i> 21(2):434-54. Salzinger, Leslie. 1997. "From High Heels to Swathed Bodies: Gendered Meanings under Production in Mexico's Export-Processing Industry." <i>Feminist Studies</i> 23(3):549-74.		
Week 7 Response 6 Movie commentary for "The 13 th " or "The House We Live in"	Movie in class: Kirby, Dick 2015. The Hunting Ground (documentary)	
	Gender, on campus: How do women deploy gendered rituals?	Andrejek, Nicole. 2021. "Girls' Night Out: The Role of Women-Centered Friendship Groups in University Hookup Culture." <i>Sociological Forum</i> 36(3):758-75.
Week 8 No response due	No class	No reading
	No class	No reading
Week 9 Response 7 Movie commentary for "The Hunting Ground"	Gender, in transit: What happens when traditional gender roles are reversed during immigration?	George, Sheba. 2000. "'Dirty Nurses' and 'Men Who Play': Gender and Class in Transnational Migration." pp. 144-74 in <i>Global ethnography: forces, connections, and imaginations in a postmodern world</i> , edited by M. Burawoy.
	Gender, in the flow of capital: How did the meaning of gender evolve as flows of transnational capital changed?	Hoang, Kimberly Kay. 2015. <i>Dealing in Desire: Asian Ascendancy, Western Decline, and the Hidden Currencies of Global Sex Work</i> . Read: pp.1-18 ("Introduction"); pp.39-77

<i>The environment</i> Supplementary readings: Givens, Jennifer E., Xiaorui Huang, and Andrew K. Jorgenson. 2019. "Ecologically Unequal Exchange: A Theory of Global Environmental Injustice." <i>Sociology Compass</i> 13(5):e12693. Gould, Kenneth A., David N. Pellow, and Allan Schnaiberg. 2004. "Interrogating the Treadmill of Production: Everything You Wanted to Know About the Treadmill but Were Afraid to Ask." <i>Organization & Environment</i> 17(3):296-316. King Leopold's Ghost (documentary). Watch: [link from BC Library]		
Week 10 Response 8	What do sociologists talk about when they talk about climate change?	Dietz, Thomas, Rachael L. Shwom, and Cameron T. Whitley. 2020. "Climate Change and Society." <i>Annual Review of Sociology</i> 46(1):135-58. doi: 10.1146/annurev-soc-121919-054614.
	Movie in class: PBS Frontline 2022. The Power of Big Oil, Part 2: Doubt (documentary)	
Week 11 Response 9	How can thinking about climate change contribute to sociology?	Elliott, Rebecca. 2018. "The Sociology of Climate Change as a Sociology of Loss." <i>European Journal of Sociology</i> 59(3):301-37
<i>The corporation</i> Supplementary readings: Dobbin, Frank. 2009. <i>Inventing Equal Opportunity</i>. Princeton University Press. Read: pp.1-21 ("Introduction")		
Week 11 (cont.)	Genesis of the corporation: Where do the corporate form as we know it today come from?	Roy, William G. 1997. <i>Socializing Capital: The Rise of the Large Industrial Corporation in America</i>. Princeton, N.J: Princeton University Press. Read: pp.3-20 ("Introduction")
Week 12 Response 10 Topic and outline for essay Movie commentary for "Doubt"	The experts: What roles do they play within the corporation?	Pernell, Kim, Jiwook Jung, and Frank Dobbin. 2017. "The Hazards of Expert Control: Chief Risk Officers and Risky Derivatives." <i>American Sociological Review</i> 82(3):511-41.

	Movie in class: Ferguson, Charles 2010. Inside Job (documentary)	
PART 2: SOCIOLOGY AS A PERSPECTIVE Supplementary readings: Calhoun, Craig J., Joseph Gerteis, James Moody, Steven Pfaff, and Indermohan Virk, eds. 2009. <i>Classical Sociological Theory</i> . Read: pp.193-202 (Excerpt from "Suicide" - Durkheim) Tucker, Robert C., ed. 1978. <i>The Marx-Engel Reader</i> . Read: pp.473-83 ("Manifesto of the Communist Party" - Marx & Engels) . Students are encouraged to read the manifesto in its entirety. Calhoun, Craig J., Joseph Gerteis, James Moody, Steven Pfaff, and Indermohan Virk, eds. 2009. <i>Classical Sociological Theory</i> . Read: pp.228-46 (Excerpts from "The Protestant Ethics and the Spirit of Capitalism" - Weber)		
Week 13 Response 11 Movie commentary for "Inside Job"	The classics: Why do we still read them?	Alexander, Jeffrey. 1988. "The Centrality of the Classics." Pp. 11-57 in <i>Social Theory Today</i> , edited by A. Giddens. Read: pp.12-32. Calhoun, Craig J., Joseph Gerteis, James Moody, Steven Pfaff, and Indermohan Virk, eds. 2009. <i>Classical Sociological Theory</i> . Read: pp.158-80 (Excerpts from "Division of Labor in Society")
	Movie in class: Hall, Stuart 1983. Marxism (documentary)	
Week 14 Response 12 Movie commentary for "Marxism"	Marx: Wage labor	Tucker, Robert C., ed. 1978. <i>The Marx-Engel Reader</i> . Read: pp.203-17 ("Wage Labor and Capital"); pp.70-8 ("Estranged Labor")
	DuBois: The Civil War	DuBois, W. E. Burghardt. 1935. <i>Black Reconstruction in America, 1860-1880</i> . Read: p.58 to beginning of 71, second para of p.79 to 83 ("The General Strike")
Week 15 Response 13 Partial draft for essay	Weber: "Ideal types" of legitimacy and bureaucracy	Calhoun, Craig J., Joseph Gerteis, James Moody, Steven Pfaff, and Indermohan Virk, eds. 2009. <i>Classical Sociological Theory</i> . Read: pp.218-227 ("Basic Sociological Terms"); pp.256-274 ("The

		Types of Legitimate Domination"; "Bureaucracy")
	Goffman: The self	Goffman, Erving. 1959. <i>The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life</i> . Read: pp.1-9 ("Introduction")
PART 3: SOCIOLOGY AS A PROFESSION No supplementary readings		
Week 16 No response	Daily work of the sociologist	TBD
	Public sociology	Burawoy, Michael, William Gamson, Charlotte Ryan, Stephen Pfohl, Diane Vaughan, Charles Derber, and Juliet Schor. 2004. "Public Sociologies: A Symposium from Boston College." <i>Social Problems</i> 51(1):103-30.
Deadline for essay and extra credit submission		

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